

BHALOTIA WITH
HIS WARDS

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New Kids on THE GREENS

A well-known coach from Kolkata stands the elite sport of golf on its head by launching a programme to teach the sport to slum children

| By Elora Sen |

It won't surprise anyone these days to know that a picture of Tiger Woods leads to fits of sniggers around every Kolkata *para*. To a group of Kolkata's slum children, though, the latest happenings around the global mega-celebrity Woods have been alarming. He was not only familiar to them but an idol of sorts.

The man behind this rare relationship is Indrajit Bhalotia, golfer and coach. For a long while now Bhalotia has been known as the man who has taken the initiative in changing the

face of the game in eastern India. In Kolkata, he has worked to change golf from being an elitist sport meant for corporate honchos to one which can be taken as a serious career by youngsters from all backgrounds. Bhalotia and his golfing academy, Protouch, have now taken it a step forward by introducing the game to a bunch of children who, when they first held a club, wondered whether they would be playing hockey or cricket.

In the past, Bhalotia had trained youngsters like Tutul Ali and Samaresh Sardar, caddies who went on to make a mark in the national cir-

cuit in their age group. The idea of training children who had never even seen a golf ball came to him when he came in touch with Ek Prayaas, an organisation that runs a school for slum children in central Kolkata. "It would have been easier to just give some money for charity, but I didn't want to do that," says Bhalotia. With the slum children, he says, what motivated him was their enthusiasm for something that was completely alien to them. He says, "They fight for survival every day, so picking up a sport is not tough for them. These children are young, so training them